

Fetishism of Commodities

The nature of the commodity may seem very self-evident and nearly axiomatic. One might think, of course we attribute exchange value to goods! How else is society supposed to function? However, it is exactly this casual attitude toward commodities that Marx cautions his readers to stay clear of. He defines the phenomenon as the “fetishism” of the commodity and its secret. It occurs when one forgets the realm of production and subsequently the factors of labor and value and strictly sees the commodity by itself in the realm of circulation, selling purchasing, and exchange value. Marx presents the example of the transformation of wood into a table. In terms of use-value, there is no mystery, because man has simply changed a form of nature and breathed life into it by giving it utility. The mystery resides in the origins of the commodity, for when the table becomes a commodity, it is no longer standing on its feet, but also on its head within the domain of its fellow commodities. Fetishism is the moment we begin attributing relations between commodities rather than between the realms of production and exchange. In the example, the synthesis of a commodity domain is the gateway drug to fetishism. And like a drug, the effects of fetishism are hallucinogenic. Marx describes the fetishist as satisfied with the belief that the only real relationships are between commodities. Returning to the example, the fetishist finds it more fantastic that he can abstract wood into a commodity than if the table were to begin dancing on its own accord. Marx, however, does believe it is possible to de-fetishize commodities by singling out the production sphere, which connects with his overarching criticism of *Capital*. The influence of fetishism arises from the non-transparency of social production under capitalism., because in capitalism, we are subjects to the master of production. Thus, de-fetishizing is a matter of liberating ourselves, the end goal for Marx obviously being communism, which in fact is a transparent mode of social production.